

MIG-19

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-19

Age: 26

Gender: Female

Country of origin: Ghana

Host country: Italy

Years in host country: 3

Occupation: Factory Worker

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to Italy three years ago seeking economic opportunity after struggling for a long time to find decent work in Ghana despite having an education and being willing to work hard at anything. The journey to get here was difficult and genuinely dangerous, one that I would not wish on anyone, but I was absolutely determined to build a better future for myself and to be able to help my family back home. I hoped to earn a real living, to send money back to support my relatives, and eventually to create some stability and security for myself here in Europe, a foothold from which to build. The reality has proven harder and more hostile than I had imagined, but the determination that carried me across the journey still carries me through the difficulties I face now.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being treated as a human being deserving of respect and fair wages, rather than being exploited and looked down upon simply because I am an African migrant, as though that made me worth less than others. It shows itself when my coworkers and the wider community accept me as an equal, seeing the person rather than the stereotype. Belonging, for me, is the feeling that I have a genuine place here, real opportunities to grow, to advance, and to contribute meaningfully, rather than merely being permitted to survive on the very margins of society, doing the work that others will not do while never being fully accepted or valued as a member of the community I contribute to.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, I face significant xenophobia and outright racism as a Black African woman in Italy, and it is a regular and painful feature of my daily life here. I have endured hostile stares from strangers, ugly racist comments directed at me, and clear discrimination in matters like housing and access to services, where doors close the moment I appear. Some people treat me as though I were inherently inferior or simply invisible, unworthy of basic courtesy or acknowledgement. The rise of anti-immigrant sentiment in the country has made everyday life a constant navigation of prejudice and occasional open hostility, requiring me to steel myself for unpleasantness in the most ordinary situations and encounters.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The challenges I have faced were immense and layered: the perilous and traumatic migration journey itself, the difficult and uncertain process of obtaining legal documents, the barrier of a new language I had to learn from nothing, and the constant struggle to find stable, decently-paid work. As an African migrant specifically, I have faced exploitation in the labour market, where employers take advantage of my vulnerable status, and discrimination in virtually every area of life. Building any kind of stable existence while simultaneously confronting racism and legal precarity has been an ongoing and exhausting struggle throughout my entire time here, one that demands resilience I did not always know I possessed.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: In the factory where I work there are other migrants alongside me, and among us there is a real solidarity born of common struggle and mutual understanding, which provides some comfort and support in a hard environment. Some of my Italian coworkers are decent and treat me fairly, while others are cold, dismissive, or openly prejudiced, making their disdain plain. The work itself is hard and physically demanding, and it is sometimes exploitative given the vulnerable status of many of us who do it, who are in no position to demand better. The support and fellowship among the migrant workers, the knowledge that others understand and share my situation, is genuinely what helps me get through the difficult days.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I hold my Ghanaian identity strongly and proudly through my faith, which sustains and grounds me through every hardship, through my language, through the food of home, and through my connection to the African community here and to my family back in Ghana, whom I think of constantly. I am learning Italian and adapting out of practical necessity, doing what I must to survive and function here, but I remain deeply and unshakeably rooted in my own culture, which is the core of who I am. My heritage gives me real strength, pride, and a sense of self amid the many challenges and indignities of life as a migrant in a place that too often does not welcome me.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Italian media too often portrays African migrants as a crisis to be managed, as a burden on the country, or as being associated with crime and disorder, rarely if ever showing us as individuals with skills, ambitions, dreams, and full inner lives. This kind of coverage directly fuels the racism that I experience in my daily life, shaping how strangers see me before they know anything about me. The reality of Africans working hard, contributing, and enduring exploitation and hardship with dignity is consistently ignored in favour of fearful, dehumanising narratives that reduce an entire diverse continent and its people to a problem or a threat. That distortion has real and painful consequences for people like me.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: Integration support for African migrants like me has been minimal in my experience, and I have relied instead on NGOs, on churches, and on the migrant community itself for the help, guidance, and human support I have needed to survive and find my way. The official programmes were difficult to

access and often inadequate to the real need when I could reach them at all. Italy depends heavily on migrant labour, on the work that people like me do in its factories and fields and homes, and yet it invests remarkably little in our actual integration, leaving many of us to struggle largely on our own to build a life in a society that wants our work but not, it often seems, our presence.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: I do not have children yet, but I think about the future generation of Africans growing up in Italy, some of them born here on Italian soil, who are nonetheless still treated as foreign and who face the same racism their parents did. I hope with all my heart that they will one day be accepted as fully Italian, belonging without question, while still being able to honour and take pride in their African heritage. The struggle for their acceptance and their genuine belonging in the only country many of them have ever known is something I think about often and worry about, because they deserve so much better than to inherit the prejudice their parents have had to endure.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, Italy must confront its own racism honestly and openly, rather than denying or minimising it, and must come to recognise the real contributions and the full humanity of African migrants who help sustain its economy and society. The media must stop dehumanising us in its coverage and start telling the fuller, truer story. Legal pathways to status and fair labour protections are essential to end the exploitation. And personal contact helps, as it does everywhere; when Italians come to know us as individuals, as coworkers and neighbours and fellow human beings, prejudice can soften. But structural change against discrimination, in law and in practice, is equally necessary and cannot be replaced by good intentions alone.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to gain stable legal status and to find better, more secure employment, perhaps one day even using my education in a proper career that matches my abilities rather than being confined to exhausting factory labour. I dream of achieving genuine financial stability, enough to support my family back home and to build a real future for myself with some security and dignity. And ultimately, I hope to live with dignity and acceptance, whether here in Italy or by eventually bringing my skills and my savings back to Ghana, so that all the struggle and sacrifice of these years will have purchased something worthwhile and lasting for me and for those I love.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to fellow migrants is to stay strong and to never, ever let the racism you encounter make you doubt your own worth and dignity, because your value as a human being does not depend on how others choose to see or treat you, however cruel they may be. Connect with the migrant community and with the NGOs that support us, because that help and solidarity are essential and you should not face these hardships in isolation. Learn the language to open doors and to defend yourself. Protect your rights firmly against exploitation. And hold onto your cultural roots and your dreams, because they are the deep source of the strength you will need to persevere through everything.